



**states** ANDHRA PRADESH

# IN RIGHT EARNEST

**Polls are two years away but campaigning has already begun as neither Congress nor TDP are willing to leave anything to chance**

**T**he next assembly elections in Andhra Pradesh are nearly two years away, but for the two main rivals, the Congress and the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), there is a sense of urgency, as if the polls were just around the corner. For the Congress, which had been out of power for nearly 10 years till it regained office in May 2004, bucking anti-incumbency is the priority. For TDP, anything less than a victory would mean a bleak future.

Both the parties, realising that the next few months are crucial, have flagged off separate comprehensive training exercises to capitalise on their strengths and fortify their weaknesses. The Congress began this exercise with the training of a select five from each of the 294 assembly constituencies who are to be both motivators and trainers and will in turn train more party activists in their districts. For its first training module, the Congress has evolved a package to hone the skills of the key activists and brief them on its activities, particularly regarding agriculture, irrigation and housing, says the Andhra Pradesh Congress Committee President Dr. K. Keshava Rao.

The party has chalked out the plans down to the last number and detail. A database of party leaders and

cadre is being made to use their services in the elections. For optimal gains from the training programme, only graduates under 45 are being recruited. Academics have been hired to impart all this in interactive mode—a 20-minute lecture followed by a 40-minute question and answer session.

As a follow up measure, Chief Minister Rajasekhara Reddy has directed his ministers to visit party offices

**DAGGERS DRAWN: Naidu addressing cadre (above); Reddy**



when they travel to the districts and the party is to conduct similar training programmes in all the 23 districts.

TDP, a party founded by former film star N.T. Rama Rao, is looking for inspiration in Rajnikant's latest blockbuster *Siraji: The Boss*. Launching a training programme for about 400 odd activists who are also doubling up as gram sarpanches in their villages, party chief N. Chandrababu Naidu suggested that they view this film and take cues from *The Boss* on how to deal with the adversary.

Plagued by internal bickering in several districts, like the Congress, Naidu, is starting afresh as he plans to involve a large number of new generation activists in the run-up to the polls.

But he has reserved the most important training input for his son and heir apparent, Lokesh, who is to accompany him on an 11-day tour to the US to meet prominent Telugu leaders and promote the activities of the NTR Memorial Trust—the fund receiving arm of the TDP.

Congress's main concern is the manner in which it believes Naidu is "provoking the people against the state government". "We will not be cowed down by the incessant criticism because no government has done what we are doing for welfare and development and these are desperate acts of political parties for their political survival," explains Reddy.

With TDP preparing for a no-holds barred campaign and the Congress also readying for a counter offensive, the training is bound to have more dimensions than enhancing the image of the parties and improving the esteem of the workers.

**by Amarnath K. Menon**

**"Lapses were there, only because we did something."**

**RAJASEKHARA REDDY, CHIEF MINISTER**